

To-Do Date: May 27 at 11:59pm

The Sleepy Lagoon Case (1942) & Zoot Suit Riots of 1943



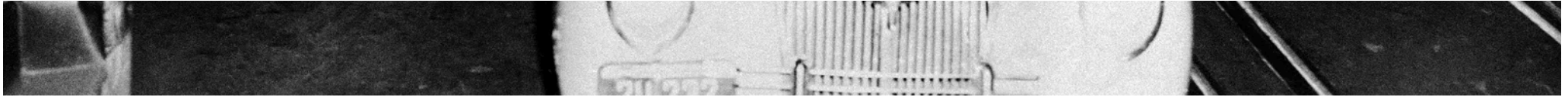


Image: History.com

For this unit, in addition to the material from *Latino USA: A Cartoon History*, we will focus on a major event in Latinx and American history: The Zoot Riots of 1943. The riots were precipitated by The Sleepy Lagoon Incident in Los Angeles in 1942. The riots mark a major turning point for Latinxs and of course are a critical part of California history. Half of this segment's discussion will focus on this era.

Do pay careful attention to this material in this module as well as your reading of *Latino USA*. There is additional reading/viewing explained and linked at the bottom of this page.

Sleepy Lagoon was an eastside Los Angeles reservoir. It was also a swimming hole and recreation center for Mexican Americans forbidden from swimming at segregated public pools. In 1942, it became a synonym of injustice and racial hatred and a starting point in the Mexican American struggle for equal justice.

On August 1, 1942, a party at Sleepy Lagoon turned violent. Fighting broke out and twenty-one year-old José Diaz was beaten to death. The local press launched a campaign against Mexican American youth.

The early 1940s in Los Angeles was the era of the "pachuco," Latino men who favored the long coats, wide pants, and long watch chains of the zoot suit. The press did a series of articles on pachuco gangs. As public outrage about the pachucos grew, sheriff's officials conducted a sweep through the city's barrios, arresting more than six hundred young men in the Sleepy Lagoon case. A grand jury eventually indicted twenty-four for murder, making the court proceedings one of the largest mass trials in American history. The defendants were referred to in the press as "The Sleepy Lagooners," and then simply as "goons." In the courtroom they were demonized as bloodthirsty hoodlums.

Access to justice was a central issue in the Sleepy Lagoon case. Only two of the defendants had attorneys and the defendants were placed in a separate "prisoners' box." Openly biased testimony was admitted into the trial record. One

Sheriff's Department expert testified that "total disregard for human life has always been universal throughout the Americas among the Indian population. And this Mexican element feels...a desire...to kill, or at least draw blood." At the trial, none of the witnesses ever testified that they saw anyone strike the victim. Some of the defendants couldn't be placed at the murder scene.

An appeals court later overturned all the convictions and severely reprimanded Judge Charles W. Fricke for displaying prejudice and hostility toward the defendants. After two years in jail and prison, the Sleepy Lagoon defendants were set free.

Strong support for the defendants came from the Citizens' Committee for the Defense of Mexican-American Youth.

Source: Digital History / https://www.digitalhistory.uh.edu/disp_textbook.cfm?smtID=3&psid=605  https://www.digitalhistory.uh.edu/disp_textbook.cfm?smtID=3&psid=605

View and annotate the two videos below that focus on the history of the Zoot Suit Riots. Be sure to take any embedded quizzes you come across.

In the short video below, we explore "How Anti-Mexican Racism in L.A. Caused the Zoot Suit Riots History." This material is from The History Channel and includes documentary footage and photos.

(5 minutes)



How Anti-Mexican Racism in L.A. Caused the Zoot

HISTORY



Watch on

"American Experience: Zoot Suit Riots" from PBS

This video includes a variety of reenactments, historical photos, and narration that dramatize the Zoot Suit era.

(52 minutes)



ZOOT SUIT RIOTS (HISTORY)

CHICANO HIPHOP CULTURE



Watch on

➔ **READ/VIEW and ANNOTATE the film and script** if you haven't yet done so!

- Click here to download the full text of the--> [Zoot Suit Play](https://modesto.instructure.com/courses/74376/files/19998185?wrap=1)
(<https://modesto.instructure.com/courses/74376/files/19998185?wrap=1>)_ ↓
(https://modesto.instructure.com/courses/74376/files/19998185/download?download_frd=1)
- [Click here to access the film version of Zoot Suit](https://login.mjc.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://digitalcampus.swankmp.net/mjc376799/watch/55176793AFBE1EEB?referrer=direct) ↗ (<https://login.mjc.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://digitalcampus.swankmp.net/mjc376799/watch/55176793AFBE1EEB?referrer=direct>)_FREE! It requires your YCCD sign-in.